

ONLY HUMAN

0.4.1

Please feel free to draw your own art.
I think this piece should be two astronauts spinning in space.
One is untethered.
They have just managed to grab on to each other's forearms.

Only Human is a game for telling sci-fi stories about competent people investigating dangerous situations on the fringes of an optimistic future.

It's for games centred on discovery rather than violence.

It's for stories about struggling against a universe that was not made for us.

Because even given everything we can fix, we are still, after all,
only human.

Perhaps this one is some people on a space station floating around a table.
They have pencils and paper in front of them.
One of them is trying to work out how to roll a die without gravity.

WORLD

It's the future. Poverty, inequity, and aging have been solved. Money and wealth have been abolished. Humanity thrives across dozens of planetary systems. Communication and travel are slow, the light barrier has not been broken, but that does not prevent the collective project of prosperity. Life has been found amongst the stars, sometimes even complex life, but nothing like humanity. Nothing we can talk to. There are always rumours, but as far as is commonly known, we remain alone.

On almost all of these worlds people lead near-perfect lives, pursuing art, knowledge, and connection. But not you. That wasn't quite interesting enough for you. On the edge of what humanity knows, there is still work to be done. There are still mysteries to be unravelled, and there are still dangers to struggle against.

BASICS

One player is the game master (**GM**). They plan and present the game's scenario, run the non-player characters (**NPCs**), interpret the rules, and adjudicate the outcomes of player actions. Everyone else creates and controls a player character (**PC**). Together the **PCs** form the **CREW**: the people sent together on a dangerous mission, or stuck together in a dangerous situation.

Everyone needs a d8 (an 8-sided die with faces numbered 1 to 8) and a way to take notes. Everyone running a **PC** needs a **CHARACTER SHEET**: somewhere to record the details of their character.

PCs have **STATS**, **SKILLS**, and a **SPECIALTY** (pages 8 and 9). A **STAT** is a number representing how good a character is at certain general actions; higher is better. A **SKILL** represents a more specific action or area of knowledge; a character with a **SKILL** is better at tasks relating to it. A **PC'S SPECIALTY** improves a **STAT**, sets their **SKILL** options, and determines their **TOUGHNESS** (page 12).

PLAY

The **GM** describes the situation the **PCs** find themselves in. Then players ask any clarifying questions and describe how their characters act. Finally, the **GM** adjudicates the outcomes of the **PC's** actions, describes the situation that results, and this process repeats.

PCs usually succeed when they take actions. This even applies to complex actions if they have a relevant **SKILL**, **SPECIALTY**, or background. There is only a risk of failure if the character is doing something they aren't experienced in or if the situation is particularly challenging.

When a **PC** attempts something, the **GM** adjudicates the outcome as follows.

- If the action is **not achievable**, tell the player. If they want to try anyway, help them narrate the failure. Otherwise, let them try something else.
- If the action is **not failable**, the **PC** succeeds.
- If there is **no cost** of failure, the **PC** tries a few times, eventually succeeding.
- If the **PC** does **not influence** the chance of success, tell the player. If they still wish to proceed, make a **LUCK ROLL** (see below).
- If the action is achievable, failable, costly, and influenced by the **PC**, then the outcome is determined by a **TEST** (page 4).

LUCK

When the outcome of an action or a situation a **PC** finds themselves in is down to chance, make a **LUCK ROLL** by rolling a d8.

- 1: **Bad**. Something goes badly for the **PC** immediately.
- 2, 3, or 4: **Warning**. Something goes wrong, but not yet. The **PC** gets a warning, and a chance to act first.
- 5, 6, or 7: **Okay**. The situation or outcome favours the **PC**.
- 8: **Good**. Things go particularly well for the **PC**.

I think this one shows something unlucky happening.

TESTS

When a PC attempts something with a chance of success, a chance of failure, and a cost of failure, they take a **TEST**. PCs also take **TESTS** when they have a chance to mitigate harm. In either case, PCs only take **TESTS** when the outcome depends on their abilities. The GM runs **TESTS** using the following steps.

First, **determine the difficulty**.

1. **Opposed:** If **OPPOSED** (page 5), the base **DIFFICULTY** is the **OPPOSITION**.
2. **Unopposed:** Otherwise, the base **DIFFICULTY** of the **TEST** is 7.
3. **Conditions:** Each **CONDITION** (page 5) that makes the test **EASIER** decreases the **DIFFICULTY** by 2. Each **CONDITION** that makes the test **HARDER** increases the **DIFFICULTY** by 2. This can modify the **DIFFICULTY** by at most 4.

Then, **determine the influence**.

1. **Stats:** Choose which **STAT** is most relevant for the **TEST**.
2. **Skills:** Ask the player to suggest relevant **SKILLS** their PC has. Decide whether you agree that any of them are relevant.
3. **Outcomes:** Decide what will happen for each **RESOLUTION** (see below).

Finally, **determine the resolution**.

1. **Inform:** Tell the player the **STAT**, **DIFFICULTY**, potential outcomes, and whether they have a relevant **SKILL**. Only proceed if the player still wishes to.
2. **Roll:** The player rolls a d8, adds the relevant **STAT**, and adds 1 if they have a relevant **SKILL**.
3. **Resolve:** Compare the result to the **DIFFICULTY** to determine the **RESOLUTION**. Describe how the previously determined outcomes play out.

RESOLUTION

Compare the **TEST** result to the **DIFFICULTY** to determine the **RESOLUTION**.

- **More than 4 lower** than the difficulty: **NO AND**.
- **Lower** than the difficulty (but not more than 4 lower): **BUT**.
- **Greater than or equal to** the difficulty (but not 4 or more greater): **YES**.
- **4 or more greater** than the difficulty: **YES AND**.

If the value on the d8 is a 1, the **RESOLUTION** is a level worse than it would otherwise be. If the value of the d8 is an 8, the **RESOLUTION** is a level better than it would otherwise be.

The **RESOLUTION** determines the outcome of the test.

- **NO AND:** The PC fails, gains 1 XP (page 6), and something gets worse.
- **BUT:** The PC succeeds but something gets worse or the PC fails but something gets better. The GM may let the player pick.
- **YES:** The PC succeeds.
- **YES AND:** The PC succeeds and something gets better.

OPPOSITION

Someone or something **OPPOSES** a **TEST** when they resist the action the character taking the **TEST** is trying to perform or when they cause the harm that the character is trying to mitigate with the **TEST**. The **OPPOSITION** is the **DIFFICULTY** of the **TEST**.

In some cases, such as for **HAZARDS** (page 11), the **OPPOSITION** is specified. If someone or something with **STATS** **OPPOSES** the **TEST**, their **OPPOSITION** is 5 plus their **STAT** most relevant to their **OPPOSITION**, plus 1 if they have a **SKILL** relevant to their **OPPOSITION**.

CONDITIONS

CONDITIONS are effects relevant to characters or situations that make actions **EASIER**, **HARDER**, or impossible. **CONDITIONS** may be temporary or permanent, and they may or may not be able to be created or removed by characters. **CONDITIONS** can apply to individual actions. If some aspect of a particular task makes it **EASIER**, **HARDER**, or impossible, that is a condition. The influence of identical **CONDITIONS** is not applied multiple times, but multiple different **CONDITIONS** can all apply at once.

A **CONDITION** that makes things **EASIER** or **HARDER** must be substantial. **CONDITIONS** must be significant enough that 2 **CONDITIONS** making things **HARDER** completely offsets any benefits of expertise: the task becomes as hard for an expert to complete as it would be for an amateur to complete without the **CONDITIONS**. Similarly, 2 **CONDITIONS** making a task **EASIER** make it as likely for an amateur to complete the task as an expert would be to complete the task without the **CONDITIONS**.

When a **CONDITION** applies to a PC the player writes it on their **CHARACTER SHEET**. The GM writes other relevant **CONDITIONS** somewhere everyone can see. You don't need to record an exhaustive list of everything that a **CONDITION** makes **EASIER**, **HARDER**, or impossible as soon as the **CONDITION** is applied, but if something isn't clear and requires adjudicating, write it down.

EXPERIENCE

PCs gain 1 experience (XP) every time they get a **NO AND RESOLUTION** on a **TEST**. Additionally, in a game with multiple sessions, if at the start of a session every player can provide the details of at least 1 distinct event that occurred in the previous session, each PC gains 1 XP.

After the **RESOLUTION** of a **TEST** has been determined, but before any consequences have occurred, a player may spend their PC's XP to improve the **RESOLUTION**. The **RESOLUTION** improves by 1 for every 1 XP they spend. If a player uses this to avoid a **NO AND RESOLUTION**, they do not gain the XP from that result.

I reckon this should show someone learning something.
Maybe a scientist in a lab examining some kind of sample?

CONSEQUENCES

The outcomes for success or failure on a **TEST** are obvious: the character does or does not achieve what they set out to do. "Something gets worse" and "something gets better" are less straight forward. The **GM** is responsible for determining the potential outcomes of a **TEST**, but the players may offer suggestions.

When things get worse the task may require more of a **RESOURCE** (page 7) than was expected, an additional challenge that needs to be overcome may be created, or a character may be harmed. Character harm and other dangers should always be telegraphed in advance.

When things get better the task may use less of a **RESOURCE** than was expected, a challenge other than the one the character was trying to address may be resolved, or a character may discover useful information.

When the **PC** succeeds but something gets worse or the **PC** fails but something gets better, the thing getting worse or better must not fully offset the success or failure. It can either partially offset it, resulting in a partial success, or it can provide some unrelated detriment or benefit.

RESOURCES

RESOURCES are things that have a measurable quantity, would have meaningful negative consequences for the **CREW** if they were to run out, and are meaningfully challenging for the **CREW** to avoid running out of.

The **GM** determines the units a **RESOURCE** is measured in and the initial amount of the **RESOURCE** the **CREW** has such that the quantities of **RESOURCES** you are tracking are manageable. Only track whole numbers, and aim to never exceed 50 units. Track these details somewhere everyone can see. Update this tracked value whenever the **RESOURCE** is used or whenever more of the **RESOURCE** is acquired.

RESOURCES may be used gradually over time or by specific actions. Time itself may be the **RESOURCE**. If a **RESOURCE** depletes over time the **GM** records the rate this happens at alongside the details of the **RESOURCE**. If the actions of a **PC** will cause a **RESOURCE** to be depleted the **GM** makes this clear to the player before they proceed. If a **RESOURCE** is required for the survival of a character that character is **DEPRIVED** (see below) of that **RESOURCE** when it runs out.

If something ceases to meet the requirements above for being a **RESOURCE**, for instance due to the **CREW** finding or creating a sustainable supply of it that is not meaningfully challenging to maintain, stop tracking it as a **RESOURCE**.

DEPRIVATION

When a character is **DEPRIVED** of a **NECESSITY** they move through 3 stages of **DEPRIVATION**. Different necessities have different time increments at which their **DEPRIVATION** progresses. After not having a necessity for the corresponding time increment, the character progresses to stage 1. After each further time increment without the necessity the stage increases.

- Stage 1: The character feels unwell due to missing the necessity.
- Stage 2: The character gains a negative condition.
- Stage 3: The character dies.

Necessity	Increment	Condition
Air	1 Minute	Mental tasks are HARDER .
Temperature	1 Hour	Movement is HARDER .
Water	1 Day	Mental tasks are HARDER .
Food	1 Week	Tasks that require strength are HARDER .

If a **DEPRIVED** character receives a **NECESSITY** for the the corresponding time increment, the stage decreases. If it reaches 0, they are no longer **DEPRIVED**.

Maybe this could be the heads and shoulders of a crew.
Their backs are to us. They are looking out a window, into space.

CHARACTERS

Each player creates a **PC** and records the character's details on a **CHARACTER SHEET**. You start by choosing a **SPECIALTY** (page 9).

Next allocate 3 points in any combination between the 4 **STATS** and add 1 additional point to 1 of the **STATS** associated with your chosen **SPECIALTY**. You may not increase any **STAT** above 3. Pick a number of **SKILLS** (page 9) allowed by your **SPECIALTY**, adhering to any specified restrictions.

PCs also have an amount of **XP** (page 6) that starts at 1, a **TOUGHNESS** (page 12) determined by their **SPECIALTY**, and an initially empty list of **INJURIES** (page 12) that they have taken. Each injury has a **WOUND** value and is either major or minor.

Choose a name and pronouns for your character. Make them more than just numbers. Consider details such as what they want, what they need (but might not know they need), their friends, their family, what they like or dislike in other people, how they know the other characters in the **CREW**, and how these things can tie into the game. Have secrets for your character, but want them to be discovered. Record these details on your **CHARACTER SHEET**.

Talk with your **GM**. Make sure your character wants whatever they need to want to engage interestingly in the scenario of the game. Talk with the other players. Make sure you make a character that wants to work with their characters.

Your **GM** will tell you what equipment your character starts with.

STATS

Characters have 4 **STATS**: strength (**STR**), dexterity (**DEX**), intelligence (**INT**), and willpower (**WIL**). For **PCs**, each is a number between 0 and 3 inclusive. Higher is better. Characters add the most relevant **STAT** to **TESTS** they take.

- **STR**: lift, carry, push, pull, hold, survive.
- **DEX**: aim, avoid, move quickly/carefully/precisely.
- **INT**: know, notice, think quickly/carefully/precisely.
- **WIL**: care, resist, struggle, strive, empathise.

SKILLS

If a character has a **SKILL**, they add 1 to relevant **TEST** results and **OPPOSITIONS**. Characters may have the following **SKILLS**:

<i>Art</i>	Understand creativity, aesthetics, and interpretation.
<i>Biology</i>	Understand life, ecosystems, and evolution.
<i>Chemistry</i>	Understand matter, chemicals, and reactions.
<i>Computing</i>	Understand information, computation, and automation.
<i>Endure</i>	Resist suffering.
<i>Force</i>	Physically move things (not yourself) forcefully, quickly, or precisely.
<i>History</i>	Understand the past, society, and evidence.
<i>Linguistics</i>	Understand communication, meaning, and patterns.
<i>Machinery</i>	Understand tools, machines, and materials.
<i>Maths</i>	Understand logic, numbers, and rules.
<i>Medicine</i>	Understand diseases, the body, and drugs.
<i>Move</i>	Move yourself forcefully, quickly, or precisely.
<i>Physics</i>	Understand motion, energy, and space.
<i>Pilot</i>	Control a vehicle.
<i>Planetology</i>	Understand planets, atmospheres, and geology.
<i>Shelter</i>	Use cover to avoid harm.
<i>Shoot</i>	Shoot something with precision.
<i>Strike</i>	Hit something with force.

SPECIALTIES

A **SPECIALTY** specifies a **STAT** or **STATS** that can receive an additional point during character creation, sets the **PC'S TOUGHNESS**, and determines the **SKILLS** the **PC** can have. If a **SPECIALTY** lists more than 1 **STAT**, the player picks from those listed. The **PC'S SKILLS** must include any required for the **SPECIALTY**.

Speciality	Stat	Toughness	Skills	Required Skill
Engineering	STR/DEX/INT	4	5	None
Medicine	DEX/INT	4	6	<i>Medicine</i>
Moving	STR/WIL	5	5	<i>Force</i>
Piloting	DEX/WIL	5	5	<i>Pilot</i>
Science	INT	4	6	A science

This one might be a diagram of a space ship.
A long thin cylinder. There are large rotating rings co-axial with the cylinder along it's length, connected by tunnels like the spokes of a wheel.

Something going wrong. Perhaps a reactor room with an alarm lit up?

TENSION

When things get tense, timing matters, so time is broken into **ROUNDS**. A **ROUND** represents about 6 seconds of the story and is made up of the following steps.

1. The **GM** describes the situation, and what happens if the **CREW** doesn't act.
2. The **CREW** and anyone helping them acts, and the **GM** resolves their actions in whatever order makes the most sense.
3. The **GM** resolves the actions of any forces opposing the **CREW**.

When a character acts in a **ROUND** they may take up to 2 **ROUND ACTIONS**. A **ROUND ACTION** could be moving, investigating something, using some equipment, creating or removing a **CONDITION**, providing quick medical treatment (page 12), attacking something or someone (page 11), or doing anything else of a similar complexity.

These actions are adjudicated like usual: they do not necessarily succeed, they may require **TESTS**, and they are not all possible in all circumstances.

MOVEMENT

When movement matters, the **GM** breaks the space the **PCs** are in down into **ZONES** that are roughly 10 metres across their longest dimension. Aim for **ZONES** that are easy to describe over getting the size right.

If the connection between **ZONES** is something difficult to move through, such as a ladder or a confined tunnel, that connection should be its own **ZONE**. If the **ZONES** are complicated, the **GM** draws a diagram somewhere everyone can see, and may use tokens to indicate where things are. Things may be in a **ZONE** or on a boundary between **ZONES**.

When a **PC** uses a **ROUND ACTION** to move, they may take up to 2 **STEPS**. Moving between a **ZONE** and one of its boundaries is 1 **STEP**.

If more **CONDITIONS** make a character's movement **HARDER** than make it **EASIER**, they can only take 1 **STEP** per **ROUND ACTION**. If more **CONDITIONS** make a character's movement **EASIER** than make it **HARDER**, they may take up to 3 **STEPS** per **ROUND ACTION**.

HAZARDS

When a hazard could hurt a **PC**, the **GM** sets it up using the following steps.

1. **Triggers:** Determine the situations in which the hazard triggers.
2. **Wounds:** Determine whether the hazard deals a 1 (low), 2 (moderate), or 4 (high) **WOUND INJURY** (page 12).
3. **Opposition:** If it is possible to resist the hazard, choose whether the **HAZARD'S OPPOSITION TO HARM TESTS** is 5 (low), 7 (moderate), or 9 (high).
4. Write these details down somewhere everyone can see.

Whenever the hazard triggers and applies to a **PC**, if the **PC** has no ability to resist the hazard, they suffer the **INJURY**. If they are able to resist, they take a **HARM TEST** (page 12) **OPPOSED** by the hazard.

If a situation would kill a character, they just die. This must be telegraphed.

VIOLENCE

When someone has resorted to violence, both timing and movement matter. Making an attack takes a **ROUND ACTION**. If an attack requires the attacker to physically strike the target with their body or something they are holding, then they must be in the same **ZONE** or on the same **ZONE** boundary as the target.

When a **PC** attempts to harm someone or something, the **GM** adjudicates the outcome of the attack using the following steps.

1. **Possibility:** If there is no chance of this attack harming the target, the attack fails. If the **PC** would know that an attack is not possible, inform the player. If they want their **PC** to try anyway, work with them to narrate the failure. Otherwise, let them try something else.
2. **Wounds:** Determine whether the attack inflicts a 1 (low), 2 (moderate), or 4 (high) **WOUND INJURY** (page 12).
3. **Resistibility:** If the target cannot resist the attack, they suffer the **INJURY**.
4. If the attack is possible and resistible, the **PC** makes a **TEST** to attack, **OPPOSED** by the target. If they succeed, the target suffers the **INJURY**.

When someone or something tries to harm a **PC**, the **GM** adjudicates the outcome as above with the **PC** as the target, but the attacker does not take a **TEST**. If the attack is possible and resistible, the **PC** takes a **HARM TEST** (page 12) to mitigate the **INJURY**, **OPPOSED** by the person or thing harming them.

If the attack is made in a way that is likely to be repeated, such as with a weapon, record the number of **WOUNDS** of the **INJURY** and any rulings made about range. Use the same decisions in the future.

HARM

Whenever a **PC** could suffer an **INJURY** that they may be able to mitigate, they take a **HARM TEST**. This follows the normal process for a **TEST**, with an **OPPOSITION** set by the source of the **HARM**.

If the **PC** fails they suffer the **INJURY**. If they succeed they reduce the number of **WOUNDS** of the **INJURY** by 1, and only suffer an **INJURY** if this does not reduce the **WOUNDS** below 1. If they get a **YES AND RESOLUTION**, they may ignore the **INJURY** unless they choose to take an alternate benefit offered by the **GM**.

INJURY

When a character suffers an **INJURY** that does not have its **WOUNDS** reduced below 1 by a **HARM TEST**, **PROTECTION**, or both: make a **LUCK ROLL**.

- **1**: If the total number of **WOUNDS** in **INJURIES** the character has taken, including the **INJURY** that caused this roll, is equal to or greater than the character's **TOUGHNESS**, they die. Otherwise, they are **UNSTABLE** and the injury is major.
- **2, 3, or 4**: The injury is minor and the character is **UNSTABLE**.
- **5, 6, or 7**: The injury is minor.
- **8**: Ignore the injury. The **PC** somehow manages to shrug it off.

Record what caused the **INJURY** and whether the injury is major or minor. If the character becomes **UNSTABLE**, they remain **UNSTABLE** until they receive medical treatment. If a character remains **UNSTABLE** for 10 minutes, they die. Whilst a character is **UNSTABLE**, they can continue to act, but everything they do is **HARDER**.

TREATMENT

INJURIES can be removed through appropriate treatment. Remove the record of an **INJURY** when it is treated, and do not count its **WOUNDS** in any future **INJURY LUCK ROLLS**.

Minor **INJURIES** can be treated quickly, with a **ROUND ACTION** whilst things are tense, provided that any required first aid equipment is available. Major **INJURIES** require specialised medical equipment and days of recovery to treat. A character can also use a **ROUND ACTION** to stabilise **UNSTABLE** characters.

As for any action, the **GM** determines whether successful treatment or stabilisation requires a **TEST**.

PROTECTION

When a character is **INJURED**, if they are wearing something that **PROTECTS** them, they reduce the **WOUNDS** of the **INJURY** by the amount of relevant **PROTECTION**. If that reduces the **WOUNDS** below 1, they are not **INJURED**.

If after any reductions a character is still **INJURED** by physical harm whilst wearing **PROTECTION**, then the **PROTECTION** is **BROKEN**, and provides no **PROTECTION** until repaired with appropriate materials.

Clothing	No PROTECTION Stylish and practical, but not particularly protective.
Hazmat Suit	4 PROTECTION against radiation and pathogens. A bright orange plastic environmental suit. Can filter external air, and has an 8-hour independent air supply.
Space Suit	1 PROTECTION against physical harm. 2 PROTECTION against radiation and pathogens. A compact vacuum rated environmental suit. Provides 8 hours of independent life support. If BROKEN , the life support capabilities deplete 4 times faster. Movement is HARDER whilst wearing a space suit.
Armour	2 PROTECTION against physical harm. Tactical body armour.

EQUIPMENT

Pad	A handheld, portable, touch-screen computer that can interface with other devices and provides text, voice, image, and video recording and (short-range) communication.
Stimpack	An injectable stimulant. When injected, roll a d8. On a 1, if the recipient has used a stimpack in the last 24 hours, they die. If they don't die, they are stabilised if UNSTABLE and can remove any number of minor INJURIES with cumulative WOUNDS less than or equal to the number rolled.
Medical Kit	A briefcase sized box containing first aid supplies, a defibrillator, and 10 stimpacks.
Vacuum Patch	A 20cm by 20cm adhesive patch that can maintain a seal between vacuum and standard atmospheric pressure.
Engineering Kit	A vacuum rated toolbox full of various equipment for dealing with the tech a space-faring engineer might expect to encounter. Includes 10 Vacuum Patches

GMING

These rules are not meant to be a legal document. They do not account for every possible situation or interpretation. When something doesn't make sense, when you find yourself having to repeatedly adjudicate the same thing, or when you want something covered more explicitly, make a ruling. Tell your players how you want something to work and write it down.

Honour the actions of the players, and roll dice in the open. Let them change the world, and face the consequences. If the players find a clever way to bypass a problem, let them. You can always come up with more interesting situations to put them in later.

Remember that a game is a series of meaningful, informed decisions. Telegraph dangers, and don't make surprise a critical element of the situations you put the **CREW** in. Try to be consistent, but not at the expense of things making sense in the moment.

OMISSIONS

These rules are general defaults. You may want to make them more specific to your game. An obvious way to do this is to add more **SKILLS**. **SKILLS** for perception, investigation, stealth, and persuasion have intentionally been omitted. Think carefully before adding them.

If a **PC** says they look in a place, they see what is there. Generally, information shouldn't be hidden behind a roll, so there is no perception **SKILL**.

Investigation is what the players do, by asking questions and taking actions to interrogate their world. It isn't some property that **PCs** have, and it shouldn't be reduced to a single **TEST**.

Stealth similarly is more interesting if it is a process. What does your character actually do to hide? Make **TESTS** using more specific **SKILLS** if appropriate.

Finally, not having a **SKILL** for persuasion helps **NPCs** feel more real. **NPCs** acting on a conversation with a **PC** isn't any different to them acting on other information. If a **PC** offers them something they want, or threatens something they care about, they assess how likely they think it is that the **PC** will follow through, and act accordingly.

These are just suggestions. Do whatever is the most fulfilling for your group. Disregard or add whatever you want. Tear the game apart. Make *your* game.

NPCs

NPCs (Non-Player Characters) are run largely like **PCs**. **NPCs** don't need **STATS** or **SKILLS** unless they are likely to help or hinder the **CREW** in situations with uncertain outcomes. If you want, you can create a character for them following the rules for creating **PCs** use any combination of **SPECIALTY** requirements. If you want to create an **NPC** quickly, give them 2 in their best **STAT**, 0 in their worst, 1 in the other 2 **STATS**, and 0 to 6 **SKILLS**.

Most of the rules for **PCs** can be applied to **NPCs**. Note though that if an **NPC** attacks a **PC**, only the **PC** rolls. If an **NPC** is working with the **CREW** consider letting a player run them mechanically, rolling the dice for any **TESTS** they take, and deciding what they do when things are tense.

Think of one word that describes an **NPC's** appearance, and one word that describes their personality. Write down a short quote they might say. Consider something they want immediately in the moment the **PCs** are likely to encounter them, and something they want from their life more generally.

DANGERS

Space is a dangerous place, and the **CREW** may encounter dangerous entities. These things might not need stats, even if they are likely come into conflict with the party. Consider whether they can be represented through **HAZARDS**.

If it is possible for **PCs** to resist the actions taken by an entity you can assign it **STATS** with values of 0, 2, 4, or 8. 4 is the peak of human ability. 8 is super human. You don't need to give it any **SKILLS**.

If it is possible for conventional weapons to harm an entity you can assign it a **TOUGHNESS** of 4, 8, or 16 and use the **INJURY** rules to track harming and killing it. If appropriate, give it 1, 2, or 4 **PROTECTION** against certain kinds of harm, but make sure to make the presence of that **PROTECTION** clear. 4 wounds with no **PROTECTION** could be taken out with a single lucky shot. 4 **PROTECTION** to everything the **PCs** can throw at it is invulnerable.

INSPIRATIONS

- Star Trek
- Dungeons and Dragons 5th Edition
- Greg Egan's Novels
- Blaster Dead Simple RPG
- Andy Weir's Novels
- Pathfinder 2nd Edition
- Outer Wilds
- Iain M. Bank's Novels
- Mothership 1st Edition
- Mythic Bastionland

HOW TO PLAY ONLY HUMAN

CHARACTERS (PAGE 8)

Create a character by choosing a **SPECIALTY**, allocating points to your **STATS**, and choosing your **SKILLS** (page 9).

TESTS (PAGE 4)

When the **GM** calls for a **TEST**:

- Roll a d8 + the most relevant **STAT** + 1 if you have a relevant **SKILL**.
- If unopposed the **DIFFICULTY** is 7.
- If someone **OPPOSES** (page 5), it is 5 + their most relevant **STAT** + 1 if they have a relevant **SKILL**.
- **CONDITIONS** (page 5) may modify the **DIFFICULTY** by up to 4.
- **CONDITIONS** that make a **TEST EASIER** decrease the **DIFFICULTY** by 2, those that make a **TEST HARDER** increase the **DIFFICULTY** by 2.

Compare the result to the **DIFFICULTY**:

- More than 4 lower: **NO AND**.
- Lower (by no more than 4): **BUT**.
- Greater (not by 4 or more): **YES**.
- 4 or more greater: **YES AND**.

The **RESOLUTION** sets the outcome:

- **NO AND**: You fail, gain 1 **XP** (page 6), and something gets worse.
- **BUT**: You succeed but something gets worse or you fail but something gets better.
- **YES**: You succeed.
- **YES AND**: You succeed and something gets better.

EXPERIENCE (PAGE 6)

- Gain 1 **XP** whenever you get a **NO AND RESOLUTION**.
- Gain 1 **XP** when everyone contributes to a session recap.
- Spend **XP** to improve the results of a **TEST**. The **RESOLUTION** improves by 1 for every 1 **XP** spent.

TENSION (PAGE 10)

When things get tense time is broken into **ROUNDS**. You may take 2 **ROUND ACTIONS** each **ROUND**.

A **ROUND ACTION** could be moving, investigating, using equipment, creating or removing a **CONDITION**, providing quick medical treatment (page 12), attacking (page 11), or anything else of a similar complexity.

MOVEMENT (PAGE 10)

When movement matters, the **GM** divides space into **ZONES**.

When you use a **ROUND ACTION** to move, you may take up to 2 **STEPS**. Moving between a **ZONE** and one of its boundaries is 1 **STEP**.

If more **CONDITIONS** make your movement **HARDER** than **EASIER**, you can only take 1 **STEP**.

If more **CONDITIONS** make your movement **EASIER** than **HARDER**, you may take up to 3 **STEPS**.